thin veneer of non-sectarianism'.[19] Iqbal expanded his criticism in a short pamphlet with the title *Qadianis and Orthodox Muslims*, where he developed the idea that claims to prophethood were severe threats to Islam's solidarity. Modern liberalism had given free rein to such 'religious adventurers' as Mirza Ghulam Ahmad, Iqbal moaned. If this liberalism would continue to force Muslims to tolerate such false prophets, '[t]he Indian mind will then seek some other substitute for religion, which is likely to be nothing less than a form of atheistic materialism which has appeared in Russia'.[20]

It was, however, not just atheism going mainstream as a consequence of liberal toleration that worried Iqbal but the dissolution of Islam itself. For Iqbal, Islam had come directly under threat from Mirza's claims of Divine revelation, as this claim entailed constructing a new spiritual authority. In Iqbal's reading of Islam, the revelation-authority nexus had conclusively come to an end with the revelations the Prophet Muhammad received. Iqbal saw this theological principle firmly established in Islamic doctrine, in what he found to be 'perhaps the most original idea in the cultural history of mankind', the finality of prophethood.[21]

Invoking the authority of the Leiden-based Orientalist Arent Jan Wensinck, Iqbal also sought to establish that the very concept of a returning Messiah had no backing in the earliest sources of Islam. Instead, its origins could be found 'in the pre-Islamic Magian outlook'.[22] Much of the backlash against the Ahmadiyya from groups like the Ahrar was justified in Iqbal's eyes. Such Muslim groups were merely following their 'instinct of self-preservation'.[23] But as their emotionally driven responses could not furnish a permanent solution to the 'Qadiani problem', Iqbal lobbied the British Government to constitutionally 'declare the Qadianis a separate community' as their theological convictions had put them outside the pale of the Muslim fold.

When Nehru received a copy of Iqbal's pamphlet on the Qadianis in Almora jail, where the colonial state had locked him away for seditious activities throughout much of 1935, his primary association with the